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PHILOSOPHY OF LANGUAGE:

Fundamental Concerns

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CHAPTER 2

REASONS WHY PHILOSOPHERS ARE CONCERNED WITH LANGUAGE

Philosophers through different epochs have shown concern with language for the following reasons: (1) metaphysics, (2) logic, (3) epistemology, (4) science and (5) consideration of language as the tool of the philosopher.

1. Metaphysical Reason

Some philosophers are of the view that the fundamental features of language represent the way reality is. Thus, knowing much about the structure of our language would serve as a gateway to a better knowledge about the nature of reality.

✓ Plato says: "Whenever a number of individuals have a common name, we assume them to have also a corresponding idea or form."¹ That is to say that we are prone to think that things with the same name have the same essence or nature. Thus, knowing the name of a thing is knowing something about its nature.

✓ Aristotle, in his *Metaphysics* used the analysis of language into subjects and predicates to point out what exists as things, what has independent existence. According to him, only substances have independent existence. Substances are ontologically more fundamental than actions, because it is substances that perform the actions. For instance, in the sentence: "Mr. Obi is running", Mr. Obi (the subject) has more ontological reality than the predicate "is running".

¹Plato, *The Republic* Bk. X (596)

✓ Russell holds that any logically correct proposition represents the structure of reality. He writes:

...in a logically correct symbolism there will always be a certain fundamental identity of structure between a fact and the symbol for it; and... the complexity of the symbol corresponds very closely with the complexity of the facts it symbolises.²

Thus, for us to understand the world well and discuss it properly, there is, first and foremost, the need to devise a “logically perfect language”, or at least find out what such a language would look like. B. Russell and A. Whitehead constructed such a logically structured language as is contained in the work they co-authored: *Principia Mathematica*. The logically perfect language is the symbolic logic. This type of language is meant to state simple facts, e.g., “The shirt is white”, or existential sentence like “There is a table in this lecture hall.” Sentences like these are called fact-stating sentences.

✓ On his own part, L. Wittgenstein holds that language pictures the state of affairs –what is the case, a fact or reality.³ “The totality of existing states of affairs is the world”.⁴ In language, says Wittgenstein, we picture facts to ourselves.⁵

The above views of Plato, Aristotle, Russell and Wittgenstein show that they believe that there is a close relation between the structure of the human language and the structure of the world. Thus, a good knowledge of the structure of language is already

² Cited in W. P. Alston, *Philosophy of Language*. New Jersey: Prentice-Hall, Inc. 1966, p. 2. Also confer R.C. Marsh (ed.) *Logic and Knowledge*. London: George Allen & Unwin, Ltd., 1956.

³ Confer *Tractatus* 2.

⁴ *Tractatus* 2.04

⁵ *Tractatus* 2.1 – 2.225

a good knowledge of the way things are in the world. For this reason, therefore, philosophy of language is of interest to the metaphysician.

2. Logical Reason

Another reason why some philosophers show interest in language is logic. Logic has much to do with language. It is in language that we state the premise and draw the conclusion. Logic is the study of inference or reasoning, and reasoning is carried on in language. To analyze various kinds of reasoning, therefore, it is necessary to analyze the language that serves as its vehicle. Let us consider the following reasoning as an example,

1. The VC of Peter University is the President of Peter University Senate.
Mr. Obi is the VC of Peter University.
 $\therefore$ Mr. Obi is the President of Peter University Senate.
2. The VC of Peter University is appointed every six years.
Mr. Obi is president of Peter University.
 $\therefore$ Mr. Obi is appointed every six years.

Argument (1) is valid, while argument (2) is not, though in appearance, the two look alike. Why then is one valid and the other not? There is need to analyze the *logical forms* of both arguments, that is, the logical forms of the sentences making up these two arguments. This will entail paying attention to the force of the verb *is* as contained in the major premise of each of the two arguments. In argument (1), *is* has the force of equality (=): the VC of Peter University = the president of Peter University Senate. In argument (2), however, *is* has not this force: the VC of Peter University $\neq$ appointed every six years.

Another example is as follows.

- (1) Mr. X is a native of Awka.
Mr. X is a student of UNIZIK.
∴ Mr. X is both a native of Awka and a student of UNIZIK.
- (2) Someone is a native of Awka.
Someone is a student of UNIZIK.
∴ Someone is both a native of Awka and a student of UNIZIK.

In this second example, argument (1) is valid while argument (2) is not. The difference in logical form lies in “Mr. X” and “Someone.” Proper name (like Mr. X) has the logical form that picks out a particular individual, but “Someone” has not this logical form.

It is by engaging in some deeper study of language that these logical structures are discovered. Thus, we can see why philosophers are concerned with the study of language for logical reasons.

3. Epistemological Reason

In the theory of knowledge, the most prominent point where philosophers become concerned with language is in the problem of *a priori* knowledge. An *a priori* knowledge is the knowledge that is independent of experience. We have *a priori* knowledge when we know something to be true without this knowledge being grounded in experience. In an *a priori* knowledge, the knowledge of the predicate is already contained in the knowledge of the subject. When a person knows well the subject, he knows the predicates *a priori*. E.g.: “A triangle has three angles”; “A quadrangle has four angles”; “A bachelor is an unmarried male adult.” The truth of each of these assertions is known independent of experience. The truth of an *a priori* knowledge can never be falsified by experience. It is not

possible that experience will disprove the knowledge that a triangle has three angles. This is so because *a priori* assertions are true by definition, that is, true by virtue of the meaning of the terms involved. For instance, if I tell a person who knows the meaning of the term "triangle" that a triangle has three angles, he is likely to tell me: "I know the *meaning* of a triangle." The philosopher of language would like to know what it is for a term to have a certain meaning and how a statement can be *true* by reason of the fact that certain terms have the meaning they have.

4. Scientific Reason

With the advent of modern science in the early modern period of philosophy and the domination of natural sciences in the late 19th century and early 20th century, the logical positivists tried to reduce philosophy to "an inquiry into language."⁶ Philosophy was given the sole task of analyzing and clarifying language for scientific purposes. Thus, the logical positivists were bent on purifying philosophy of every element of metaphysics so as to allow it develop as a branch of logic. The role of this branch of logic would be that of "explicating terms which belonged to scientific methodology."⁷ The philosopher in this sense would "bring the resources of modern formal logic to bear upon such concepts as those of testability, or confirmation, or probability, or truth."⁸

Francis Bacon, in his work *Novum Organum* expresses the importance of a philosophical clarification of our ordinary day-to-day language for better precision in scientific thought. He argues that words are born out of popular, unscientific and

⁶A. J. Ayer, *The Concept of A Person and Other Essays*. London: MacMillan, 1963 (Reprinted 1973), p. 3

⁷*Loc. Cit.*

⁸*Ibid.*, pp. 3 – 4

vulgar minds; thus, they lack the precision needed for scientific thinking. It was for this reason that philosophers like Frege, Russell and Whitehead attempted to construct a more scientific language – the symbolic logic. The *Principia Mathematica* co-authored by Russell and Whitehead is the living sample of this scientific language, a language which is believed to be perfect and free from ambiguities, but a language that remains dead because there is no community that uses it.

5. Consideration of Language as the Tool of the Philosopher

Verbal discussion is considered to be the philosopher's laboratory in which he puts ideas to test. This being the case, there is need that this all-important tool for doing philosophy should be in order. It is true that thinkers in other fields of human inquiry complain about the inadequacy of language, but it is the philosopher who has more to do with language. Therefore, he has more reason to seek for the reform of language in order that this becomes a better effective tool for doing philosophy. Many philosophers feel that our language is quite inadequate for formulating fundamental truth about the world. Plotinus and Bergson, for example, were of the opinion that language is quite inadequate for the formulation of fundamental truths about the world. Thus, they advocated for a wordless union with reality for one to really apprehend the truth.

Wittgenstein, for instance, is of the view that "Most of the propositions and questions of philosophers arise from our failure to understand the logic of our language".⁹ "All philosophy", thus becomes "a 'critique of language'¹⁰, "a battle

⁹*Tractatus* 4.003

¹⁰*Tractatus* 4.0031

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against the bewitchment of our intelligence by means of language."¹¹

How do we do this battle against the bewitchment of our intelligence? There are two groups of philosophers who complain about the inadequacy of language. These two groups are ordinary language philosophers and artificial language (or symbolic logic) philosophers.

(a) **Artificial Language (Symbolic Logic) Philosophers.** These are those who think that the philosophical problems arise from the fact that our day-to-day language (ordinary language) is inadequate for philosophical purposes, because it is full of vagueness, inexplicitness, ambiguity, context-dependence and misleadingness. In this group, we have such philosophers as Leibniz, Frege, Russell, early Wittgenstein (*Tractatus*) and Rudolf Carnap. These philosophers consider it their duty to construct an artificial language that is logically structured in a perfect way that it can properly, clearly and distinctly represent reality. From the structure of such a language, we can easily read off basic facts about the metaphysical structure of reality.

In the *Tractatus*, Wittgenstein proposes an ideal logical language in which each proposition should have a particular state of affairs it pictures, and in which each word stands as a definite name of a definite object.

(b) **Ordinary Language Philosophers.** These philosophers hold that the language of everyday discourse (*die Umgangssprache* – the language of the man-in-the-street) is perfectly suitable for understanding and discussing about reality. Problems arise with language only when men

¹¹ *Philosophical Investigations*, paragraph 109.

(especially philosophers) deviate from the ordinary use of language without really providing reasons for the deviation. Locke, for instance, complained against the scholastic jargons. Later Wittgenstein (*Philosophical Investigations*) opines that our problems of philosophy stem from the fact that philosophers have misused certain important terms like “know”, “see”, “true”, “think”, “pain”, “free”, “reason”¹²: “For philosophical problems arise when language goes on holidays.”¹³ That is to say, philosophical problems arise when philosophers remove words from their ordinary home, which is their ordinary usage in day-to-day lives and activities of human beings. Problems arise with regard to language when philosophers take the ordinary word and exile it in a metaphysical world. It becomes the duty of the ordinary language philosopher “to bring words back from their metaphysical to their everyday use.”¹⁴ There developed in Cambridge University a group known as Ordinary Language Philosophers who championed a call for a go-back to ordinary language in order to avoid pseudo philosophical problems arising from the abuse of ordinary language by some philosophers.

¹²L. Wittgenstein, *Philosophical Investigations*, paragraph 116.

¹³*Ibid.*, paragraph 38

¹⁴*Ibid.*, paragraph 116.

CHAPTER 3

THE PROBLEM AND THEORIES OF MEANING THE PROBLEM OF MEANING

The philosopher of language is interested in knowing what it implies for a word or any other linguistic expression to have certain meaning, for instance, when I say that "foreknowledge" means the "knowledge of an event before it happens." In the theory of meaning, philosophers try to bring out what it is for a word to have a certain meaning. When we solve this fundamental philosophical problem of knowing what it is for a word or linguistic expression to have certain meaning, we can then try to solve other problems pertaining to meaning. Some of these other problems are as follows: Under what conditions do two linguistic expressions (two words) have the same meaning – the problem of synonyms? Under what conditions are we justified in saying that a word has two different senses in two different contexts? What is the difference between a literal and figurative meaning of a term? What causes a word to change its meaning over time? How do children learn the meaning of words? Do proper names like Dick, Obi, Chioma and so on have meaning? What kinds of meaning are there? For example, is there any distinction between cognitive meaning and emotive meaning?

It is clear that for us to answer these other questions we need first of all to know what it is for a linguistic expression to have a certain meaning. This fundamental problem must be solved so as to serve as a foundation for the solution of other subsequent problems relating to meaning in language. It is the task of the philosopher of language to make explicit what it is for a word to have a certain meaning. In so doing, he provides a firm foundation for these other special inquiries about

language that are of interest to social scientists, anthropologists, psychologists, linguists etc. We can state the problem of meaning in another form: What are we saying about a word when we say what it means? Or again: What does a person know when he knows the meaning of a word?

For the sake of precision, we can state the problem of meaning in the following question.

How does a word/linguistic expression mean? Or

What is it for a word/linguistic expression to have certain meaning? Or

What are we saying about a word when we say what it means?

Or

What does a person know when he knows the meaning of a word?

The possible answers to the problem of meaning give rise to different theories of meaning.

Theories of Meaning

What does a person know when he knows the meaning of the word "table", for example? The following are the possible answers, which correspond to the existing theories of meaning.

1. He knows the object to which the word "table" refers – referential theory.
2. He knows the idea the speaker has in mind when he utters the word "table" – ideational theory.
3. He knows how to react at the utterance of the word "table" – behavioral theory.
4. He knows how to use the word "table" – meaning as use theory.
5. He knows how to verify the truth of the expression "table" – verification theory

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6. He knows how to translate the word "table" – translation theory

The first three theories of meaning – the referential theory, the ideational theory and the behavioral theory – are known as traditional theories of meaning. The other three theories are new theories.

1. Referential Theory of Meaning.

The referential theory of meaning is the theory that for any word (or linguistic expression) to have a meaning is for it to name, designate, or refer to something (an extra-linguistic reality) other than itself. This view seems to originate from the opinion that proper name is the typical unit of meaning. With the proper name, the bearer it refers to is just clearly there. At the mention of the proper name "Ada", for instance, the person it refers to stands there, and all who know the bearer of the name know that the word "Ada" refers to her. When, for example, I say "Ada", and a person nearby points to Uju who is near to Ada; Uju is likely to say: "He does not mean me, but her", pointing at Ada. Proper name, as it were, labels an individual distinctly. Referential theory of meaning seems to simplify the problem of meaning and to remove all the mysterious elements involved in the problem until one asks: what makes the word "Ada" the name of this girl and not of the other girl?

Proper names designate particular individuals. Where a word refers to a particular individual, as is the case with proper names, we say that the word *designates*. However, when a word refers to a kind of thing (as with common names like "man", "horse", "table" – universals), we say that it *denotes*. Reference by a singular term or a proper name is *designation*, while reference by general terms (common nouns, a state of

affairs, a relationship) is *denotation*. To understand words as symbols that stand for something other than themselves, is to have the referential view of meaning.

Referential theory of meaning can exist in a naïve or a sophisticated version. Generally speaking, referential theory is the view that for an expression to have a meaning is for it to refer to something other than itself. While the naïve view locates meaning to the entity the linguistic expression refers to, the sophisticated view locates meaning to the *relation* between the linguistic expression and its reference. In other words, the naïve view is that the meaning of an expression is the object in the external world to which the word refers, while the sophisticated view is that the meaning of the expression is to be identified with the relation between the linguistic expression and its reference – that is to say that the referential *connection* constitutes the meaning. The naïve version of the referential theory can be proved to be inadequate by showing that meaning and reference are not identical.

Meaning and Reference

Can we correctly say that the meaning of a word is its reference? In other words, are meaning and reference identical? The answer is no. Two expressions can have different meanings but the same reference. This point is clearly demonstrated by Gottlob Frege in his famous essay “Sinn und Bedeutung” (“On Sense and Reference”).¹ Frege illustrated his point with the linguistic expressions “the morning star” and the “the evening star”. “The morning star” has a meaning different from “the evening star”, though both linguistic expressions

¹Confer G. Frege, “On Sense and Reference” in Robert M. Harnish (ed.), *Basic Topics in Philosophy of Language*. (New York: Harvester Wheatsheaf, 1994), pp. 142 – 160

have the same reference. Both refer to the same extra-linguistic entity, the planet Venus. If "the morning star" has the same meaning as "the evening star", a person could know that the morning star is the same entity as the evening star just by understanding the meanings of the terms (as with "My mother is the same entity as "the woman who gave birth to me"). But this is not the case. The fact that the morning star and the evening star are the same was an astronomical discovery which took years and long search and research to arrive at. It is a *posteriori* or synthetic knowledge, not *a priori* or analytic knowledge. That two linguistic expressions have the same reference is *aposteriori* knowledge. It is knowledge from experience, not from the analysis of the meaning of the linguistic expressions. This shows that the two linguistic expressions, though they refer to the same extra-linguistic entity, have different meanings.

The above point can be illustrated by the following examples: "the first Polish Pope" and "the Polish man canonized a saint in 2014". "The first Polish Pope" does not mean "the Polish man canonized a saint in 2014", though both refer to one person – Pope St. John Paul II. No analysis of "the first Polish Pope" will ever give us "the Polish man canonized a saint in 2014". It is only by experience that a person can know that the both linguistic expressions refer to the same individual.

B. Russell in his renowned article "On Denoting"² demonstrated that two expressions could have the same reference without having the same meaning. E.g., "Sir Walter Scott" and "the author of *Waverley*" which, though refer to the same individual, have different meanings. Let us also illustrate

²B. Russell (1905), "On Denoting" in Robert M. Harnish (ed.), *Basic Topics in the Philosophy of Language*. (New York: Harvester Wheatsheaf, 1994), 161-173

this point with the following example: “the Odenigbo 1999 lecturer” and “the author of *Things Fall Apart*.” “The Odenigbo 1999 lecturer” does not at all mean “the author of *Things Fall Apart*,” though the two expressions have the same reference – Prof. Chinua Achebe. Russell went further to show that an expression can have meaning without denoting anything, that is, without referring to any extra-linguistic reality, e.g., the “The King of France.” Though this expression has meaning, it refers to no entity. There is no “King of France.” We can talk of “round triangle”, but this does not exist in reality; thus the expression has no reference, though it makes some sense. Further, such words as “and”, “is”, “so” etc. have no references, though they make sense; they have meaning.

In addition to the above, there are cases of an expression having different references. In such a case, we have sameness of expression or meaning but different references. This is the case with a class of terms called “indexical terms”, e.g., ‘I’, ‘you’, ‘here’, ‘this’, ‘that’ etc. which systematically change their reference with changes in the condition of their utterance. When Ben utters ‘I’ it refers to Ben, when Amaka utters it, it refers to Amaka. However, this does not mean that ‘I’ has different meanings corresponding to these differences. ‘I’ has a single meaning, and it means *the speaker*. Its reference, however, varies according to who the speaker is. To learn the meaning of the word ‘I’, a person does not need to know all to whom ‘I’ can refer. It suffices for him to learn that this English word means *the speaker*.

With all the above, it becomes clear that the meaning of a word is not identical with its reference. Meaning is not identical with reference. To mean is not to denote. Referring is not coextensive with meaning. If to have a meaning is to refer to

something, then it must be possible to find a reference for every meaningful expression, including whole sentences. But we do not ordinarily think of a sentence as itself referring to something. The referential theory of meaning is superficial because it does not take seriously enough the necessity of specifying what it is that connects an expression with its reference; that is to say, it fails to point out in what constitutes the word-world (language-reality) relation. Other theories of meaning try to supply this lack.

2. Ideational Theory of Meaning.

The ideational theory of meaning pays attention to the inner connection between conscious ideas and speech behavior, in the mind of the speaker and the words he utters or writes. One of the outstanding statements of the ideational theory was that by the renowned 17th Century British philosopher, by name John Locke. He says that words are the "sensible marks of ideas; and the ideas they stand for are their proper and immediate significations."³ That is to say that the meaning of a word is the idea it stands for.

Behind this view lies the conception that language is essentially an instrument for the communication of thought. This is an expressionist conception of language: the assumption that thought (idea) exists independently of language. According to this view, thoughts are accessible only to their possessor. For others to know of his thoughts, the possessor makes use of publicly observable sounds and marks as representations of these thoughts or ideas. In communication, the speaker aims at making his audience get at the ideas in his mind by means of language. Communication is

³ J. Locke, *Essay Concerning Human Understanding*. Bk. III, chapter 2, section 1.

successful to the extent the utterance of the speaker succeeds in arousing in his hearer the same idea that led the speaker to its utterance. Thus, the meaning of a word is the idea in the mind of its user. The ideational theory of meaning is the theory that the meaning of an expression is the idea it expresses. The proponents of this theory tend to think of the meaning of expression somewhat as if they were specimens in a museum of ideas each labelled with the proper expression.

The assumption that thought exists independently of language is faced with many philosophical criticisms. B. Russell, for example, writes:

Language serves not only to express thought, but to make possible thought which could not exist without it.⁴

And for Wittgenstein, “language is itself the vehicle of thought.”⁵

Criticism: The ideational theory can work only if for every meaningful linguistic expression, there is an idea that is regularly associated with it. This is not the case. In a meaningful sentence, we have many words that have no distinct ideas associated with them. To explain meaning in terms of word-idea association implies that we need to bring in ideas that are identifiable apart from recognizing what the word means. Are there such ideas – such specimens in a museum of ideas, existing apart from language? In other words, are there concepts existing in the mind independently of language? The assumption that there are such ideas is the reason why Locke and his followers have devoted much attention to sensory

⁴ B. Russell, *Human Knowledge: Its Scope and Limit*. London: George Allen & Unwin Ltd., 1948, p. 74.

⁵L. Wittgenstein, *Philosophical Investigation* tr. G. E.M. Anscombe. (Oxford: Basil Blackwell 1968, first published in 1953), paragraph 329.

imagery – sensory image that would be introspectively recognizable apart from language, but they did not succeed in finding sensory image for every linguistic expression.

If the meaning of the word is the idea in the mind of the speaker, what then gives meaning to those ideas that are themselves but thoughts? Thought and language are inseparable. They seem to be two sides of the same coin. If thought does not exist without language, and language is made up of words, we can say that the ideational theory of meaning begs the question when it says that the meaning of a word is the idea in the mind of the speaker.

3. Behavioral Theory of Meaning

Were we to follow the ideational theory of meaning, we must settle questions about meaning by looking for ideas in the minds of speakers and listeners. However, this is not the way we settle disputes about meaning. If I want to know what a speaker means by the word “independence”, for example, I do not try to find out by asking him what imagery accompanied his utterance of the word. In most of the case, we settle the dispute about meaning by some sort of public consensus. This strongly suggests that meaning is a function of publicly observable aspect of language situation. The meaning of words is known from the overt behavior of those who make use of them. Normally, on hearing a word a person understands, the person reacts in a certain way. The word elicits some overt behavior in the hearer. In its naïve form, the behavioral theory of meaning asserts that the meaning of a linguistic expression is the situation in which the speaker utters it and the response that it calls for in the hearer.

Criticism: Behavioral theory of meaning fails to take into account the fact that a word can be uttered in a great variety of

situations, and there seems to be nothing connecting all these situations that could serve as the meaning of the word used in these situations. A word can also elicit a variety of reactions in a hearer without anything serving as the link between these reactions. The problem with behavioral theory is that there are many factors that affect a person's response on hearing the utterance of a linguistic expression: past experiences, level of education, beliefs, expectations, fears etc. Thus, we make the two following conclusions. (i) On different occasions a hearer makes very different responses to the utterance of a given expression, even when used in the same sense. Also, on the same occasion varied responses are made by different hearers to the utterance of a given expression. (ii) Sometimes there is no overt response at all. The linguistic expression: "There is beer in the fridge" for example, could elicit different reactions from different hearers, and also from the same hear in different situations. Which of these varied reactions is to be taken as the meaning of the linguistic expression?

Evaluation of the Three Traditional Theories of Meaning

The problem of each of the three traditional theories of meaning is that of oversimplification. (1) The referential theory is of the view that each meaningful unit is connected with something distinct and concrete in the extra-linguistic world. (2) Ideational theory is a supposition that each meaningful unit has a fixed association with a particular "idea" or "sensory image". (3) Behavioral theory seems to be a search for a regular stimulus-response association in which words figure. The last two theories seem to suggest that the meaning of a word is to be identified with something that happens every time it is used. Thus, we have to look for what Roger Brown calls "click of comprehension". This "click of comprehension" is to be found either in the mind (ideational theory) or in the

overt behavior (behavioral theory) of he who understands the meaning of the word. Does such a click really exist?

*The common problem of the traditional theories of meaning is that they seem generally to believe that a meaning is a sort of entity: an object, an idea or a definite overt behavior, as the case may be. It is not possible to identify the meaning of a word with any entity not already specified within the language as a meaning.

All said and done, we have, from the traditional theories of meaning, gained some insight into the nature of language and meaning. Referential theory teaches us that language is used to talk about the extra-linguistic world. Ideational theory brings to our awareness that language somehow expresses our thoughts and ideas. Finally, the behavioral theory makes us know that language use elicits some behavior in the hearer and that words have meaning by virtue of the way they figure in a human behavior.

4. Use Theory of Meaning

To overcome the oversimplification and other deficiencies of the traditional theories of meaning, a new analysis of meaning was given birth to by the philosophical works of the Austrian philosopher, Ludwig Wittgenstein⁶, at Cambridge University in the 1930s and 1940s. According to Wittgenstein, the meaning of a word or a linguistic expression is its use: "the meaning of a

⁶In this discussion on meaning all the references to Wittgenstein are to what scholars call "Later Wittgenstein". By that they mean works of L. Wittgenstein that are later than his *Tractatus* to which they refer as "Earlier Wittgenstein". The main work of Later Wittgenstein is the *Philosophical Investigations*.

word is its use in the language”⁷. From this stand of Wittgenstein came the general saying as we have it today: “Meaning is use”, or “Don’t look for the meaning, look for the use.” Wittgenstein himself tells us: “Look at the sentence as an instrument, and at its sense [meaning] as its employment [use]”.⁸

Later Wittgenstein is against any view that suggests that the meaning of a word is an entity. Such a view is a misunderstanding of the term ‘meaning’. On this Wittgenstein writes:

It is important to note that “meaning” is being used illicitly if it is used to signify the thing that ‘corresponds’ to the word. That is to confound the meaning of a name with the *bearer* of the name.⁹

According to Wittgenstein, the meaning of a word is to be sought and found in its use. Thus, he rejects ostensive definition – definition of a word by pointing to the object the word refers to. He rejects ostensive definition on two major grounds. In the first place, ostensive definition is misleading to the person who has not got the meaning of the word within a language-game. For example, if I point to a black book in order to explain the word “black”, to a person who has no idea of what the word “black” means, the person could understand from my pointing the following: “book”, “book cover”, “thick object”, “color”, “colored object”, “black”, “flat surface” etc. Therefore, this type of definition is not a definitive method of defining because, according to Wittgenstein, “ostensive definition can be variously interpreted”.¹⁰

⁷L. Wittgenstein, *Philosophical Investigation*str. G. E.M. Anscombe. (Oxford: Basil Blackwell 1968, first published in 1953), paragraph 43

⁸*Ibid.*, paragraph 421

⁹*Ibid.*, paragraph 40

¹⁰*Ibid.*, paragraph 28

By ostensive definition, the learner can sometimes guess the meaning right and sometimes wrong.¹¹ The second reason why Wittgenstein rejects ostensive definition is that it is not applicable in all cases, like in the following words: "time", "meaning", "foresight", "therefore" etc.

Another way people try to explain the meaning of a word is by verbal definition. This, however, gets us no further, for, according to Wittgenstein, "it takes us from verbal expression to another"¹², leading us either to a vicious circle or to infinite regress.

How then do we get at the meaning of a word? It is, according to Wittgenstein, by getting at its use: "If we had to name anything which is the life of a sign, we should have to say that it is its use".¹³ Pointing out in what consists the meaning of a word, Wittgenstein rhetorically asks: "But doesn't the fact that sentences have the same sense consist in their having the same use?"¹⁴ We are to note well that Wittgenstein is not saying that the term "meaning" is synonymous with the term "use". By the use of a word he means the special circumstances, the surroundings, in which the word is used. The meaning of a word is to be determined in the language-game in which it plays a part. Hence, the meaning of a word is its use (*Gebrauch*) or its employment (*Verwendung*) or its application (*Anwendung*).

¹¹*Ibid.*, paragraph 32

¹²L. Wittgenstein, *The Blue and Brown Books* dedicated by Wittgenstein to students; (Oxford: Basil Blackwell, 1969), p. 1

¹³Loc. Cit.

¹⁴L. Wittgenstein, *Philosophical Investigation* str. G. E.M. Anscombe. (Oxford: Basil Blackwell 1968, first published in 1953), paragraph 20

B. Russell (1940) held a similar view about the meaning of words: "Words are used in many ways: in narrative, in request, in command, in imaginative function, and so on."¹⁵ Words do not mean any specific thing, but have many meanings depending on the way and the circumstances they are used. The language-game or the universe of discourse in which a word is used plays some role in determining the meaning of the word. In line with this view Russell writes:

In the meaning of a sentence, there are three psychological elements: the environmental causes of uttering it, the effects of hearing it, and... the effects which the speaker expects it to have on the hearer.¹⁶

John L. Austin's classification of linguistic acts into locutionary, illocutionary and perlocutionary acts also views meaning of a word or linguistic expression as lying in its use. In his work on "Speech Acts"¹⁷, J. L. Austin holds that to say something is to do something. Three different actions can be accomplished by saying something: locutionary act, illocutionary act and perlocutionary act.

(a) **Locutionary act** is the act of talking; it is the verbal activity.

(b) **Illocutionary act** is the performance of an act *in* saying something. For example, asking question, answering question, making promise, making a declaration, baptizing, condemning, blessing, cursing, conversing, pronouncing sentence, teaching, giving some information, or an assurance or a warning, giving

¹⁵ B. Russell, *An Inquiry into Meaning and Truth*. London: Unwin Paperbacks, 1940, p. 26.

¹⁶ *Ibid.*, p. 27.

¹⁷ J. L. Austin, "Locutionary, Illocutionary, Perlocutionary" in Robert M. Harnish (ed.), *Basic Topics in Philosophy of Language*. (New York: Harvester Wheatsheaf, 1994), pp. 30 - 39

a command, consecrating, exclaiming, etc. A person can say that to perform a locutionary act is in general to perform an illocutionary act at the same time. Convention and authority are very important for the performance of certain illocutionary acts.

(c) **Perlocutionary act:** saying something will normally produce certain consequential effects upon the *feelings, thoughts or actions* of the audience or of the speaker or of other persons. While speaking the speaker can encourage, irritate, amuse, inspire, discourage, impress, distract, embarrass, scandalize, bore, attract attention, etc. At times, the speaker speaks with the design, intention or purpose of producing such an effect, while at other times he may not have the intention of doing so. Thus, by speaking, the speaker accomplishes another action in the hearer or in himself. This is what we mean by perlocutionary act.

When, for instance, I say to someone: "You are a fool", the person may say: (a) He *said* to me: "You are a fool"; (b) He *insulted* me; (c) He *provoked* me. In this example (a) is a locutionary act, (b) is an illocutionary act, while (c) is a perlocutionary act.

5. Verification Theory of Meaning

The Logical Positivists in the 1920s came up with what they tagged "Principle of Verification" which holds that the meaning of a proposition is the method of its verification. According to the logical positivists, there are two ways of verifying: (i) observation and (ii) analysis. Only the proposition whose claim is observational or analytical is meaningful. Any proposition whose claim cannot be observed or analyzed has no truth value: it cannot be true or false; it is simply meaningless, in which case it is no proposition in the true sense of the word. A proposition properly called is a sentence that is

true or false, that is to say that a proposition has truth value. Alfred J. Ayer on the principle of verification writes:

The principle of verification is supposed to furnish a criterion by which it can be determined whether or not a sentence is literally meaningful.... A sentence had literal meaning if and only if the proposition it expressed was either analytic or empirically verifiable.¹⁸

This principle functions both as a theory of meaning and as a criterion of meaningfulness. It was invented to demonstrate the meaninglessness of all metaphysical assertions, which according to logical positivists, are neither analytical nor observational. The principle of verification holds that the meaning of a proposition is the method of its verification. To know the meaning of a proposition is to know how to verify it. Therefore, to the question what does a person know when he knows the meaning of a linguistic expression, the verification theory of meaning would say: he knows how to verify the claim of the linguistic expression.

Criticism: Verification, in the sense the logical positivists employ it, is not a criterion of meaning. There are meaningful linguistic expressions that are neither analytical nor observational. Even the principle of verification itself is neither analytical nor observational; but we cannot correctly say that it is senseless.

* 6. Translation Theory of Meaning

In translation it is believed that the translator carries the meaning of a linguistic expression from its original language (the source language) to another language (the receptor language). In this sense, translation is understood as the act of carrying across the meaning of a word or any other linguistic expression from one language into another language. Thus, to

¹⁸A. J. Ayer, *Language, Truth and Logic*. (New York: Dover Publications, INC., 1952), p.5

the question: "what does a person know when he knows the meaning of a word/linguistic 'expression?'" we can answer that he knows what to carry across from the source language of the word/linguistic expression into another language. In other words, when a person knows the meaning of a word, he knows how to translate it into other languages that he knows. Simply put, the translation theory of meaning is the view that meaning of a word or a linguistic expression is its equivalent in another language.

Criticism: The problem with this theory is that there is hardly a complete equivalent between a word and its translation in another language.¹⁹

Conclusion

In conclusion, we say that each of the theories of meaning discussed in this chapter contains some truth about the meaning of word or linguistic expression. However, the meaning of a word is to a large extent determined by the way the word is normally used in a linguistic community. Words are public property, just as language itself. It is a fundamental mistake to say that one gives certain intention or purpose or that the words one uses lose their meaning if one misuses them. A word is a common possession of the linguistic community, and it has the meaning(s) it has by virtue of some general facts about what goes on in that community, and the way the community members normally use the word. It is in this sense that Wittgenstein denies the possibility of private language.²⁰

¹⁹See the problem of incomplete equivalent in translation as discussed in chapter 4 below.

²⁰L. Wittgenstein, *Philosophical Investigations*, tr. G. E. M. Anscombe. (Oxford: Blackwell, 1968), paragraphs 199 & 243. For deeper reading on Wittgenstein's Private Language Thesis, see B. I. Ewelu, *Private Language Thesis and Its Epistemological Import: A Study in Philosophy of Language* (Enugu: Delta Publications, 2008)